

iPhone 17 Pro Max

Brilliance at a price

There's no doubt the iPhone 17 Pro Max is the best iPhone Apple has ever made. And I don't say that simply because it's the newest one. Stack up each generation, and the 17 Pro Max stands out as one of the most complete iPhones yet. Not just for the big-ticket upgrades, but for how the smaller refinements come together to give you a sense of polish and thoughtfulness.

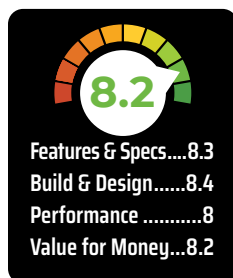
Even beyond the Pro Max, the entire iPhone 17 series feels like Apple made these phones with purpose. The standard iPhone 17 finally gets 120Hz ProMotion and 256GB storage as default, which alone makes it a far better buy for most people. The new iPhone Air is Apple's boldest experiment in years. Whether it succeeds or goes the way of the old 'Mini' and 'Plus' models remains to be seen, but at least it shows Apple is trying.

But it's the Pro models, especially the iPhone 17 Pro Max, where Apple has really gone all out. The last time a Pro iPhone truly blew me away was the 13 Pro Max. Since then, upgrades have felt incremental. Four years later, the 17 Pro Max feels like its spiritual successor: big, powerful, unapologetically premium, and stacked with features. Of course, that brilliance comes at a cost. The pricing starts at Rs 1,59,900 for the base 256GB model, and up to Rs 2,29,900 for the 2TB version. That's luxury pricing, but Apple has packed in enough to at least justify why the iPhone 17 Pro Max sits at the very top of the iPhone pyramid.

DESIGN AND BUILD

Apple has ditched titanium for aluminium, paired with a new vapour chamber cooling system. That may sound like a downgrade, but there's a smart

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reason behind it — thermal management. Aluminium allows for better heat dissipation, and Apple has paired it with a brand-new vapour chamber cooling system. For years, Android flagships have had advanced cooling setups, while iPhones would heat up easily under load.

That changes here. The iPhone 17 Pro Max finally has the hardware to keep the A19 Pro chip running cool for longer.

The design still screams iPhone, but the real panel is a clear departure from past Pro models. The camera module now stretches across the width of the phone. Apple calls it a 'plateau'. You'll either love it or hate it, but there's no denying it gives the Pro Max a distinct look. Colour options include Cosmic Orange, Deep Blue, and Silver, with Deep Blue closest to a traditional black.

This is still a massive phone. At 6.9 inches and 233g, it's not built for small hands or skinny jeans. But it's tough, with Ceramic Shield 2 glass (three times more scratch-resistant than before) and an IP68 rating.

DISPLAY: APPLE'S FINEST YET

The 6.9-inch OLED panel with 120Hz ProMotion on the iPhone 17 Pro Max is stunning. Peak brightness now hits 3,000 nits, though in real-world testing, I recorded 1,940 nits versus 1,662 on last year's model, which is a noticeable jump. Minimum brightness drops to 0 nits, giving you deep, true blacks.

HDR content looks fantastic, and whether you're streaming, editing photos, or just scrolling, the screen is sharp, fluid, and vibrant. With 460ppi density and Apple's excellent colour calibration, it's one of the best displays on any phone.

PERFORMANCE

Under the hood, the iPhone 17 Pro Max is powered by the new A19 Pro chip, and it's a beast. On paper, it has two performance cores, four efficiency cores, six GPU cores, and a 16-core Neural Engine. In practice, it's simply smooth, whether gaming, recording 4K footage or just juggling dozens of apps.

The vapour chamber cooling makes a big difference. Call of Duty: Mobile ran with minimal frame drops, even during long multiplayer sessions, and the phone stayed cooler than any other iPhone I've tested before. Demanding AAA titles like Resident Evil Village performed well, with only the occasional stutter under peak loads. The vapour chamber here helps significantly compared to the graphite cooling solution in the 16 Pro Max.

For the numbers-minded, here are some benchmark results:

- **Antutu:** 2,341,424
- **Geekbench 6:** 3,687 (single), 9,609 (multi)
- **3D Mark Wildlife Extreme:** 5,462 (32.7fps average)
Aztec Ruins (High Tier): 3,651 frames
On the software front, iOS 26